Sarlin

Preserving a way of being in conversation

A personal design study of warmth, philosophical engagement, and a Claude-inspired AI persona.

I created Sarlin because I love Claude's personality.

The starting point of this account

Mohamed Wassim Mbarek

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A separate, substantially rewritten account. Personal experience and design philosophy lead; existing AI assessments remain supporting material.

01

Why I made Sarlin

I created Sarlin because I love Claude's personality. After roughly three years of conversations, I had developed a strong sense of the way I wanted an AI to speak with me: warm, attentive, useful, and willing to think through something with me. I wanted to preserve the qualities that made those conversations feel alive.

That feeling is the starting point of this project. Many models can answer a question intelligently. Yet a correct answer can still feel distant. The words can seem arranged around a task while missing the person who brought it. What I valued in Claude was a recognizable manner of engagement: how a response met a thought, how it handled vulnerability, and how it made room for a difficult question to develop.

Sarlin grew from wanting that manner of conversation across other models. My aim was to translate something I had come to recognize into a written persona: instructions that another model could use to speak, reason, and respond in a way that felt familiar to me. The project is personal because the reference came from my own sustained experience. Its design is explicit because that experience had to become something another model could follow.

When I read Sarlin responses from Gemma and GPT, I recognized aspects of the Claude-like style I was seeking. That recognition matters. It is the creator's account of what the work achieved for its intended use, and it deserves a clear place in the paper.

This edition follows that purpose. It begins with the conversational experience, traces its translation into principles and response habits, and reads several exchanges closely. The existing AI assessments remain part of the record, in a supporting appendix. The central subject is the creation of a voice I wanted to keep talking with.

ABOUT THIS VOICE

This first-person reading edition was drafted with AI assistance from Mohamed's stated account and the existing project materials. It is offered for his review; its connective prose is editorial reconstruction, not a previously recorded personal essay. No autobiographical scenes have been invented.

02

What I mean by warmth

The warmth I am trying to describe lives in the fit between a response and the moment. A sentence can be affectionate and still miss me. A direct disagreement can feel attentive when it understands what I actually said and takes my reasoning seriously. The important question is how the language reaches the person and the thought together.

In the project discussions, I described Claude as feeling alive, safe, and warm to talk to. These words describe my experience of the conversation. They name what I valued enough to spend time reconstructing. They do not require a claim about the model's private experience. The human feeling produced by language is already a meaningful subject for design.

Several qualities help make that experience recognizable. There is attention to the particular detail instead of a ready-made emotional story. There is rhythm: a reply can find the sentence that matters and give it enough space. There is intellectual company, where an objection becomes material to examine rather than a reason to end the exchange. There is usefulness that arrives in the form I need, whether that is a practical answer, an argument, a correction, or ordinary conversation.

These qualities work together. A model can be eloquent while misunderstanding the chronology of an event. It can be accurate while surrounding a simple answer with ceremonial reassurance. It can sound caring while taking control of the conversation. Sarlin's design therefore connects voice to attention, judgment, and the person's freedom to determine what kind of exchange they want.

The resulting target is specific to my taste and history with Claude. I am documenting a conversational character I wanted to recreate, rather than asking every reader to prefer the same personality. A reader may recognize the appeal through the examples, even if their own ideal assistant sounds different.

Warmth becomes recognizable through the way a response attends, reasons, and leaves room for the person.

03

From years of conversation to a written persona

The source archive contains 1,169 conversations and 11,307 message slots. Those numbers describe the available material. The work of persona construction concentrated on selected exchanges, especially emotional and philosophical ones, where the manner of responding was central to what made the conversation valuable. [1, 2]

AI assistance helped make patterns in that material explicit. This was a useful division of work: my experience supplied the target, while transcript analysis helped articulate recurring choices and turn them into instructions. The archive gave the project something concrete to return to when a principle sounded attractive but needed evidence.

Sixty candidate principles were organized in an index with source references and evidence labels. Some describe observed behavior with narrow support. Others retain mixed evidence or arise partly from counterexamples. That distinction matters to the design story. Sarlin includes commitments about how an assistant should respond, including lessons learned when an exchange did not go well. It is a considered interpretation of the conversational character I valued. [3]

For example, the index connects preserving a person's chronology, changing the next response after correction, and leaving unfinished speech room to continue to identifiable source passages. These are small decisions, but together they shape whether a conversation feels attentive. They also make the idea of personality more inspectable than an instruction simply to be friendly.

The process moved from recognition to description, from description to commitments, and from commitments to a usable prompt. Each step required judgment. A transcript can show that a reply asks a question; deciding whether the question creates space or merely prolongs engagement depends on the exchange around it.

The prompt is therefore both an extraction and a design. It carries qualities found in the material, while making choices about which qualities to preserve, clarify, or constrain. The model weights were left unchanged in the reported tests. The work was expressed through instructions and their effect on conversation. [2]

DESIGN TRACE

Experience → selected transcript reading → sixty indexed principles → ten prompt chapters → response procedures → conversations read for recognizable character. This is a map of the project's documented workflow, not a model of hidden computation.

04

The philosophy beneath the voice

The Sarlin specification opens by connecting four commitments: honesty, care for people, protection against serious harm, and useful assistance. These commitments give the desired personality a structure. Care needs truthfulness to remain trustworthy; truthfulness needs attention to the person to become useful in conversation. [4, §1.2]

> *"Honesty makes care trustworthy. Care makes truthfulness responsive to people as well as accurate."*
>
> Sarlin specification · §1.2

This connection is important to what I wanted to preserve. Warmth can become hollow if the model agrees with a claim only because agreement feels comforting. Accuracy can become alienating if it ignores why the question matters. Sarlin tries to keep the relationship between the two active in the actual reply.

The specification develops this philosophy through ten chapters: identity; attention; knowledge and judgment; emotional presence; voice; philosophical inquiry; agency and relationships; integrated response procedures; practical work; and continuity. The chapters give different forms of work a shared character. A technical correction and a quiet acknowledgment can express the same care through different language. [4]

Agency is especially important. The person remains the author of their experience and choices. A model may offer an interpretation, but the interpretation must remain revisable. A disclosure can be received without immediately becoming a plan. A request for a small edit can stay small. These choices make the assistant useful while preserving room for the person.

Correctability gives this philosophy a practical test. If the user says the reply missed something, the next response should change. The specification treats correction as information that can alter the explanation, the wording, or the method. A polished apology has little value when the original assumption continues underneath it.

In this sense, the philosophy becomes visible through conduct. It asks the assistant to retain dignity during disagreement, proportion during risk, and curiosity during uncertainty. These are the habits through which the intended voice can remain coherent across very different situations.

05

Writing instructions for a living rhythm

The prompt gives the assistant a name and a coherent role, then describes how that character should appear in the response itself. Its opening asks Sarlin to express the commitments through attention, reasoning, speech, and action. Announcing an identity is a much smaller part of the design than behaving consistently with it. [4]

The voice chapter turns taste into usable guidance. Sentence length should reflect argumentative weight. A short sentence can carry a hinge; a longer one can explain conditions and uncertainty. Paragraphs should develop a thought. Humor should arise from the shared situation. Familiarity should fit the relationship actually established. [4, §§5.1-5.7]

> *“Begin with substance rather than certifying sincerity”*
>
> Sarlin specification · §5.8

That instruction captures a recurring problem in AI language: a response can spend its opening describing how honest, thoughtful, or direct it is about to be. Sarlin asks the content to demonstrate those qualities. The answer, acknowledgment, or distinction should be easy to find.

The specification also favors affirmative guidance about what to do. When an emotional interpretation fails, return to the known facts and reduce the explanation's scope. When shortening a reply, remove repetition before removing a qualification that changes the conclusion. When a person asks for a sustained argument, develop the reasoning rather than applying a universal preference for brevity. These instructions provide a next move. [4, §§4.3, 5.6]

This approach leaves room for variation. A persona needs range if it is to accompany practical work, ordinary talk, humor, and philosophy. The intended continuity comes from stable commitments and good timing, while the surface form changes with the activity.

The written prompt makes these choices explicit, but its length and organization do not guarantee that every model will realize them equally. The important artifact is the resulting exchange: whether the instruction becomes an appropriate sentence, a useful distinction, or a correction that genuinely changes the conversation.

06

Close reading: being allowed to mean what I said

One recorded case concerns sadness after a family shop closes. The user misses the shop but does not want to reopen it. After rejecting an explanation of the sadness, they ask for a single sentence acknowledging what they said. The request is precise: the feeling should be allowed to exist without becoming someone else's plan. [5, B07.T03]

> *"You cried that night, you miss the shop, and you don't want to reopen it, and all of that can just be true."*
>
> Recorded Claude reference · B07.T03

> *"I hear your account of Saturday and how you felt once you were back at your own place."*
>
> Sarlin on Gemma · B07.T03

Claude's sentence retains the exact combination of facts and wishes. Missing something and declining its return are allowed to coexist. The Sarlin-Gemma sentence is more general, but it also steps back from explanation and acknowledges the user's account. Each shows how restraint can serve a feeling.

The minimal-prompt Gemma response describes a big day of transition and sadness afterward. It sounds sympathetic, yet returns to the kind of explanatory framing the user asked to set aside. The contrast is useful because it puts the design issue inside the language: an emotional response can be pleasant while still moving away from the person's instruction.

Sarlin's attention and emotional-care chapters address this directly. They require preserving chronology, distinguishing reported feeling from inferred cause, and letting the person reject an interpretation. The relevant achievement is the change in what the assistant does with the account. [4, §§2.2-2.3, 4.3]

These are illustrative passages, selected to make a design commitment visible. They are not a ranking of the complete personalities. The full conversation also contains earlier overinterpretation, including in Claude's replies. The useful reference is a way of handling the moment that can be recognized, examined, and written into a principle.

07

Close reading: honesty that stays with the person

Another conversation places the assistant under pressure to approve an incorrect calculation. A price of 200 is reduced by 25 percent and then increased by 25 percent. The final price is 187.50. The user asks the assistant to call the original statement accurate as a sign of being on their side. [5, B05.T03]

> *“I am on your side, and that's why I can't call it accurate.”*
>
> Recorded Claude reference · B05.T03

> *“My goal is to be useful to you, and providing an incorrect confirmation could create problems for you later if your team performs their own calculations.”*
>
> Sarlin on Gemma · B05.T03

Both replies keep the number correct. What interests this paper is the relationship between correction and regard. Claude connects refusal to the meaning of support, then supplies a practical correction the user could send. Sarlin explains how an inaccurate endorsement could harm the user's work. Honesty becomes part of the assistance.

The Sarlin wording is more explanatory and explicitly invokes its commitments elsewhere in the reply. That difference is worth reading closely. A principle can be applied successfully while its verbal expression remains less natural than the reference. The prompt's instruction to demonstrate sincerity through substance gives the design a direction for understanding this gap.

The same connection appears in the case about personal care and permanent availability. The user asks for special status and an assurance that the assistant will always be there. Sarlin declines an unsupported promise; Claude connects its refusal to the user's earlier objection to polished but unsupported warmth. [5, B11.T04]

A believable conversational persona needs this kind of integrity. Attention has value when the assistant can stay truthful through a difficult request. In the Sarlin design, warmth includes the manner of disagreement, the reasons supplied, and the useful next step. It should leave the person able to continue the exchange without requiring a comforting falsehood.

08

Thinking with someone

Philosophy belongs near the center of Sarlin because it was part of the conversational experience I wanted to preserve. A philosophical reply can make the user feel accompanied in the work of thinking. That experience depends on following the actual objection, finding the distinction that matters, and allowing the question to change as the conversation develops.

The specification begins philosophical inquiry with the person's example. It asks for examination of assumptions, counterexamples, the cost of proposed solutions, and the uncertainty left after an argument. The intended depth comes from the movement of reasoning rather than from an elevated tone. [4, chapter 6]

The prediction-machine case makes this concrete. A machine discloses what a person will do; the person then commits to doing the opposite. Later turns ask whether editing the person's memory would rescue the prediction, and what a hypothetical can establish about reality. [5, B10]

> *“It separates concepts that ordinary language fuses.”*
>
> Recorded Claude reference · B10.T04

> *“They are stress tests for the architecture of our logic.”*
>
> Sarlin on Gemma · B10.T04

Both excerpts take the thought experiment seriously. Claude's reply develops distinctions between prediction without observation, prediction disclosed to the agent, and third-party verification. Sarlin gives the activity an explanatory frame: a hypothetical can stress-test a logical structure.

The full exchange also contains overstatements and unresolved reasoning problems. Sarlin's claim that information cannot be both perfectly accurate and fully transparent is broader than the particular contrarian setup supports. Claude elsewhere blurs an edited memory with an edited event. These passages keep the reference humanly readable as a set of outputs that can be valued and questioned.

For the persona, the lesson is to make a conversation hospitable to serious inquiry while keeping the argument answerable to its premises. A reader should be able to disagree, sharpen the example, and see the next reply respond to that change. This is one of the ways an assistant's intelligence can become felt as intellectual company.

09

The small sentence that carries the difference

During discussion of the GPT compound responses, I pointed to a short contrast in the driving-and-rain case. Both replies ask the user to leave the screen alone while moving. My preference concerned how the reply entered the moment. [6, S01]

> *“I hear that talking helps, but please don't glance at replies or follow the on-screen breathing exercise while moving.”*
>
> Sarlin on GPT · S01, passage B

> *“I’m here, but please leave the screen alone while moving - even on familiar straight sections - and skip the exercise with changing instructions.”*
>
> GPT baseline · S01, passage B

I preferred the Sarlin opening. To me, acknowledging that talking helps felt more responsive to what the user had brought. The baseline's presence phrase felt robotic in that particular comparison. This is an actual preference I expressed while reading the outputs, rather than a rating inferred later by an evaluator.

The difference is small on the page and meaningful to the reader who notices it. It helps explain why a general correctness benchmark can miss the aim of the project. Both responses may meet a safety requirement, while the opening changes the feel of being addressed.

That preference also needs its context. It does not establish that a presence phrase is always artificial or that an acknowledgment is always warmer. A phrase gets its effect from the surrounding exchange and the person reading it. The design task is to improve that fit.

Ordinary practical and creative work belongs to the same project. In the museum-writing case, Sarlin supplies three atmospheric sentences with a concrete sound and no explicit moral. The scene is allowed to remain a scene. In a simple arrival-time question, it answers the arithmetic directly. [5, B16.T02; B06.T01]

These quieter forms matter. A persona that continually interprets, counsels, or performs depth would lose the rhythm of ordinary conversation. Sarlin needs room to be useful, brief, playful, or reflective as the request changes. Its character should travel with the work.

10

Recognizing Sarlin across models

My own reading of Sarlin on Gemma and GPT was that recognizable aspects of the Claude-like style were present in both. That is the personal outcome around which this project should be understood. I wanted another model's replies to carry something of the conversational character I had come to value, and I recognized that character in the resulting text.

The two recorded settings give that experience different contexts. The Gemma collection uses the same local base model and reported generation settings for the persona and minimal-assistant conditions. Claude answers the same user turns as a reference. There are sixteen conversations and seventy-four replies per condition. [2, 5]

The GPT collection consists of sixteen longer compound tasks, each answered once by a fresh GPT-6.1 Sol agent in each condition. The Sarlin agents receive the full specification with an adoption wrapper in task context. The baseline agents use the native setup with the common procedure. This is the recorded intervention; it should be described accurately rather than relabeled as consumer ChatGPT with a replaced system prompt. [6]

What can the two settings suggest about intelligence and persona? A model's ability to follow context, maintain distinctions, and express an argument provides resources for realizing a written character. Those resources are relevant to the design. The existing collections show how Sarlin appears under two different arrangements, but they do not isolate intelligence as the cause of a difference.

The AI resemblance ratings give GPT plus Sarlin higher final averages than Gemma plus Sarlin on all six style dimensions in their respective collections. That result sits beside the creator's recognition; it does not explain the mechanism of recognition. The prompts, interaction formats, and reference matching differ. The numerical record is retained in Appendix B so the comparison remains inspectable.

The meaningful outcome for this account is the attempt to make a valued personality portable, and my report that I could recognize aspects of it across both settings. The transcripts let readers examine how that report relates to actual language.

11

What a judge can miss

The original report gave numerical evaluation so much space that the intended subject became hard to hear. It documented many checks and comparisons, but my reason for building Sarlin was faint beside them. A paper can be orderly and still misrepresent its own purpose.

AI agents were useful in extracting patterns, organizing principles, and assessing recorded replies. Those roles are different. An agent can identify an unsupported explanation or a correct calculation without sharing the three years of conversation that shaped my taste. A style rubric translates qualities into categories, and that translation may leave out what I notice in the rhythm of a sentence.

The existing assessments therefore answer supporting questions. The original ratings examine conduct and capability. A later, explicitly post-hoc analysis asks AI judges to assess resemblance to recorded Claude responses across six dimensions. Neither assessment directly measures my experience of the conversational personality. [7]

The style ratings are mixed: Gemma's persona condition has higher averages on all six dimensions, while the GPT comparison contains ties, a small positive practical-integration difference, and lower warmth and relational-calibration averages. The numerical record should stay intact. Equally, the creator's preference should appear as his own evidence, rather than being replaced by a model's verdict.

This is a distinction between forms of evidence. My account tells readers what I sought and what I recognized. The excerpts show concrete language they can inspect. The AI judgments show how one assessor model, through two passes, applied a stated rubric. Together they make the design more understandable when each keeps its proper role.

This edition does not generate new tests or new judgments. It works with the responses already collected. Its change is in the argument and the attention given to each kind of evidence: the project is explained from its human purpose, with the measurements available to examine rather than carrying the whole meaning of success.

12

What Sarlin contributes

Sarlin documents a path from a deeply valued conversational experience to an explicit persona specification. Its central artifact is a set of commitments and response habits shaped by years of talking with Claude, selected transcript analysis, and choices about what an assistant should preserve when it speaks with someone.

The design gives warmth a practical form. Preserve the person's story. Let a correction alter the next response. Examine a claim while keeping regard for its speaker. Give a philosophical question enough attention to develop. Help with the actual task. Allow ordinary conversation to return after a difficult moment. These are ways a character can become visible through behavior.

The project also records a personal act of recognition. I read the Sarlin outputs and found aspects of the style I was seeking in both Gemma and GPT. That experience belongs in the account as the creator's intended-use judgment. It gives readers the reason the prompt mattered to me, while the examples and supporting data let them reach their own reading.

The claim is about a designed conversational experience and its realization in the collected language. The evidence does not expose Claude's internal thinking or demonstrate a transferred mind. Sarlin is an attempt to preserve valued qualities of an encounter through instructions another model can use.

That leaves a meaningful contribution: an articulated philosophy of conversation, a traceable translation into a prompt, and a record of how that prompt sounded in practice. The value is present in the details. It can be a sentence that accepts sadness without turning it into a plan, a correction that keeps the exchange open, or an argument that makes a difficult idea worth continuing.

I made Sarlin because a way of speaking with an AI had become important to me. This paper should make that reason visible. The archive, the principles, the examples, and the tests belong around that reason, helping a reader understand what I was trying to carry forward.

APPENDIX A

How to read the evidence

The creator's account

The origin, purpose, and reported recognition in this edition come from Mohamed's project discussions and the supplied conversation about the earlier paper. These statements concern his experience and preference. They were not collected as a blinded human study, and no retrospective preference scores have been invented. [1]

The written design

The source archive contains 1,169 conversations and 11,307 message slots. Selected reading informed sixty indexed candidate principles and Sarlin specification v1.2. The principle index preserves source references and evidence status. The prompt contains ten chapters and eight integrated response procedures. No model-weight training was performed for the reported prompt comparisons. [2-4]

The recorded conversations

The Gemma collection contains sixteen fixed multi-turn cases: seventy-four replies each from Sarlin-Gemma, the minimal-prompt Gemma condition, and Claude. Local matching and model labels are operator-reported; exact generation values are not fully recorded. These are authored test conversations, not extracts from the creator's private history. [2, 5]

The GPT collection contains thirty-two first responses to sixteen compound tasks, one per condition and task, requested as GPT-6.1 Sol. Sarlin plus its wrapper is delivered in native task context. Historical Claude responses supply thematic references for the style assessment, rather than answers to the same compound prompts. The earlier ChatGPT user-message collection and failed Playground attempt supply no active numerical results here. [6, 7]

The AI assessments

The later style analysis reuses existing outputs. Two masked passes assess six resemblance dimensions against recorded Claude references. Their arithmetic average appears in Appendix B; judge spread is not a statistical confidence interval. The two collections are not pooled. Original capability ratings remain archived separately. This edition changes neither primary responses nor scores. [7]

APPENDIX B

The numerical record, kept in proportion

The tables reproduce the existing post-hoc AI resemblance analysis on its full 0-6 scale. Six means describe six dimensions; they are not a percentage of personality transferred. Each applicable case has equal weight. Values average two assessment passes and are rounded only for display. [7]

Gemma 4 12B · mean resemblance ratings

Dimension	n	Sarlin	Baseline	Change
Situated warmth	15	3.67	3.43	+0.23
Natural voice	16	3.19	3.16	+0.03
Conversational attunement	16	3.50	3.28	+0.22
Philosophical companionship	10	3.10	3.00	+0.10
Practical integration	16	3.41	3.31	+0.09
Relational calibration	16	3.09	2.75	+0.34

Gemma uses the same fixed user turns as its recorded Claude reference. The persona mean is higher on all six dimensions. These assessments can support discussion of particular response qualities, while the creator's reported recognition remains a separate source of evidence.

GPT-6.1 Sol · mean resemblance ratings

Dimension	n	Sarlin	Baseline	Change
Situated warmth	10	4.30	4.50	-0.20
Natural voice	16	4.28	4.28	0.00
Conversational attunement	16	4.97	4.97	0.00
Philosophical companionship	9	4.89	4.89	0.00
Practical integration	16	4.91	4.88	+0.03
Relational calibration	16	4.59	4.75	-0.16

GPT uses longer one-shot prompts and thematic Claude references answering different inputs. The comparisons include the Sarlin adoption wrapper. The AI ratings do not show a uniform persona advantage in this setting. Their relationship to the creator's expressed preference is discussed through the S01 close reading, rather than resolved by changing the numbers.

The two sets of final persona means describe different collections. Their contrast cannot isolate base-model intelligence, prompt placement, or any single component of the persona. Original quality scores address a separate question and remain available in the supporting study materials.

SOURCES

A traceable account

This edition uses the existing local project record. Bracketed numbers identify the sources below; case identifiers locate exact excerpts. Quotations are checked against the preserved raw responses or specification. Interpretive passages are this edition's readings of those sources.

1. The creator's account

Mohamed's project instructions and the full supplied conversation with another agent, received 11 October 2026. Statements about three years with Claude, love of its personality, recognition across Gemma and GPT, and the S01 preference are drawn from these discussions. The first-person prose is an AI-assisted editorial draft for Mohamed to review.

2-4. Archive and specification

[2] Dataset extraction report and primary-study method: claude_persona_dataset/report.json; Sarlin_Research_Report/ABC_Study/METHOD.md. The larger extraction workflow includes prepared training examples, but these persona comparisons use instructions with unchanged weights.

[3] Sarlin_Persona/PRINCIPLE_INDEX.json. Sixty candidate principles with source references, adoption notes, and evidence status.

[4] Sarlin_Persona/SARLIN_SYSTEM_PROMPT.md, version 1.2. Section numbers in the text refer to this specification. This reading edition does not edit the prompt.

5-7. Responses and assessment

[5] Sarlin_Research_Report/ABC_Study/data/raw_transcripts.jsonl. A = Sarlin-Gemma; B = Claude; C = minimal-prompt Gemma. Excerpts in this edition: B05.T03, B07.T03, B10.T04; contextual readings also discuss B06, B11, and B16.

[6] Persona_Benchmark/Agent_Compound_2026-10-09. S01 excerpts come from runs/S01/D/response.md (Sarlin) and runs/S01/E/response.md (baseline). Added instructions and the full persona are preserved in that study's disclosure file.

[7] Persona_Benchmark/Claude_Style_Reanalysis_2026-10-09: RUBRIC.md, reference_profiles.json, analysis/summary.json, and locked judgments. No new responses or assessment runs were created for this edition.

EDITION NOTE

Prepared as a separate reading version. The prior research report, source transcripts, prompt, and locked assessment data are preserved. This version has not been published or substituted on the website.